Upon arrival at a digital rehab, doctors say they spend the first few sessions simply getting to know the person and the nature of their addiction. In extreme cases, this can take up to weeks. "There is no one size fits all solution," says Dr Sharma. "What draws a person online differs vastly—some do it to combat loneliness, others to become popular, yet others to escape the offline world." Once the cause for addiction is identified, therapists help patients find ways to combat the urge that drives them to constantly check their devices. Support from family and friends is crucial at this stage. "Finding offline hobbies has been proven to help many patients," adds Dr Sharma.

Guidance from a professional counsellor is a must. "Going to a therapist does not mean you are weak or mentally unsound," says Dr Tilwe. "Sometimes people need help to understand and modify their behaviour." In Amrita's case, since she was forcing herself to do more work simply to generate content to post online, her therapy had to focus on helping her find validation and approval from within.

Some counsellors have even tied up with digital experts to help patients delete their digital footprint and reduce enticing notifications. "I had a patient who wanted to remove all posts she had put up when she was going through a bad divorce," says Chennai-based counsellor Dr Ashok Bhaskar. "So we worked with a social media expert to help her understand how much of her online life was going to stay stored permanently as digital data, and how much she could realistically delete. It helped her become more cautious about what she was putting out in cyberspace."

Going offline, therefore, is not just a question of willpower but also of being technologically savvy. "Turn off your notifications for some hours daily, put your phone on silent, change your privacy settings...these are some technical suggestions that can help reduce the presence of digital devices in daily lives," says Mumbai-based counsellor Dr Hirak Patel.

Self-regulation is another option. "Two days a week, my two children and I do not use phones at all," says 41-year-old Kanika Kalra, a Bengaluru-based homemaker. "I am helping them to see the world outside of their screen."

Indeed, educating both parents and children on the healthy use of devices is more important today than ever before. "Kids also learn behaviour from their parents and family members," says George. "For healthy digital use, everyone needs to participate and practise balanced usage."

Many parents are coming up with ways in which digital use can be monitored and optimised (see *Breaking the Shackles*). "Families now face the challenge of how to effectively monitor their child's behaviour, interactions and time spent on various online spaces. Many are using technology to counter the use of technology," says Zaidi. This includes apps such as Netnanny and Kaspersky to help parents keep tabs on what their children are watching online. "One of the best measures can be spending quality time with children so that they get distracted from their devices," adds Zaidi. Some children themselves have begun implementing the 20-20-20 rule where every 20 minutes, they take a 20 second break and look 20 feet away for 20 seconds. "The pandemic has made me realise how much more I use my phone and laptop," says nine-year-old Delhi student Shekhar Sahu. "In school they have taught us the 20-20-20 rule and I now follow it because I care about my health."

> **"NOW THAT MY DAUGHTER AND I USE OUR SCREENS LESS, WE FIND OURSELVES LOOKING FORWARD TO THE OUTDOORS AND OFFLINE CONNECTIONS"**
>
> **KANIKA KALRA**
> *Homemaker, Bengaluru*

Experts say that even if there is no addictive behaviour in the house, parents can eliminate any chance of future addiction by implementing ground rules from the start. Dr Bhattacharya says, "While giving your child a mobile phone, you should explain its advantages and disadvantages in detail. You should also ensure that everyone in the house follows digital rules." Having rules is what has helped Kalra and her two children rediscover the joys of the offline playground, offline games and offline meetings. "2019 onwards, we had forgotten what it was like to touch mud, walk on dry leaves, feel a gust of wind. Now that we use our screens less, we find ourselves looking forward to the outdoors and offline connections," she says. As the digital world becomes more alluring through artificial intelligence, virtual reality and augmented reality, the health of individuals and society will lie more and more in the balance. It is up to us to save our souls. ■

–with Shelly Anand, Daya Shankar Shukla and Aditi Pai